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The Yoruba of Southwestern Nigeria

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The length of the body is measured with a stick and a simple grave is dug in the room of the deceased or, if he had none of his own, in the room of his father. Before beginning their work the grave diggers demand drinks of his children. If there are many children, they may take several days to complete the work so as to enjoy more food and drink, digging only a foot or so and then stopping to eat and drink. If the deceased was elderly, the grave diggers joke while they work to make his children forget some of their sorrow and laugh a little; but if he was their own age or younger, they do not joke while they work and they do not ask for food and drink. The last bit of dirt removed from the grave is saved to be used when creditors come to claim debts owed by the deceased; unless the debts are common knowledge, the creditors are made to eat a little of the dirt while taking an oath that the debts are legitimate.

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Each younger sibling by the same father and the same mother is responsible for providing a cloth for the burial. The family of the father of the deceased jointly contributes one cloth, the brothers and sisters of the mother provide one cloth each; close friends may contribute cloths voluntarily. When a man dies, each of his wives must also provide a cloth in return for the one with which he covered her during their first intercourse; but if she has children, they provide the cloth jointly in her name. When a woman dies, her husband and each of her children are responsible for a cloth in which she will be buried. Sisters and daughters share in these responsibilities, even if in former times they had to be indentured to meet them, until they became engaged, after which their "husbands" assume their responsibilities for them. Grandchildren are not expected to contribute to the funerals of their grandparents, unless their own parents are not alive to do so. The body may

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be buried in as many as eighty cloths, and even a poor family tries to provide at least four. No cloth with any red in it can be used in burial, so that the deceased will not be reborn as a leper.

Interment was formerly delayed as many as eight days, as long as the children of the deceased could afford to feast the male and female members of the sub-clan who were junior to their parent, and their guests. Interment now follows as soon as the grave has been dug, often shortly after the corpse has been bathed and shaved. The body is wrapped in the cloths which have been contributed and tied with skeins of cotton thread. Two hundred cowries (six-tenths of a penny) were traditionally put inside the cloths so that the deceased could pay the gatekeeper of heaven; but by 1937, as much as ten shillings was given by wealthy individuals. If there are enough cloths to hold the body upright, it is balanced and allowed to stand for five minutes or more; but this form of ostentation is dangerous because it is believed that, if the body should fall, a member of the sub-clan will follow it to the grave. If the men who bathe the corpse and dig the grave are pleased with the  food and drink they have been given, they carry the corpse about the compound in a farewell visit before it is lowered into the grave, and sometimes the empty coffin is first carried about town.

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